Unit 3

From Chiefdoms to Empires



ABASG6

Learning Objectives

- To know the factors responsible for the rise of Janapadas and Mahajanapadas.
- To understand the evolution of Indian polity from Chiefdoms to Kingdoms.
- To recall the greatness of Mauryan Empire.
- To learn the main features of the administration and the nature of the society & economy during that time.
- To gain the knowledge on Ashoka's policy of Dhamma.
- To examine the causes for the decline of Mauryan Empire.

Importance of Sixth Century BC (BCE)

During the sixth Century BC (BCE) many territorial states emerged. This Led to the transformation of socio – economic and political life of the people in the Gangetic plains. A new intellectual awakening began to develop in northern India. Mahavira and Gautama Buddha represented this new awakening.

Role of iron in a changing society

Iron played a significant role in this transformation of society. The fertile soil of the Gangetic Valley and the use of iron ploughshares improved agricultural productivity. In addition, iron facilitated craft production. Agrarian surplus and increase in craft products resulted in the emergence of trading and exchange centres. This in turn paved the way for the rise of towns and cities. Thus, knowledge in the use of iron gave Magadha an advantage over other Mahajanapadas. Thus the Magadha could establish an empire of its own.

Gana - sanghas and Kingdoms

There were two kinds of government in north India during the sixth century BC (BCE)

- Gana - sanghas – non monarchical states.
- Kingdoms - monarchies

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